

ON THE FLOOR

FROM THE PICTURE WINDOW IN THE VISITOR'S GALLERY, I BEGAN to wonder about how to get down to the floor. Everything seemed to revolve around this handful of specialists, who were running the entire sale for themselves and had been kept so quiet the average investor had never heard of them. If only there were a way of looking over their shoulders and finding out what they were doing. Who knows what useful bit of gossip, or what profitable little fact could be picked up from watching these merchants process their orders there in the middle of the paper debris.

With that in mind, I called up the public relations office of the New York Stock Exchange and requested a floor visit plus a chat with any specialist. Unfortunately, I got nowhere. You'd imagine they'd be more eager to please the average investor, whom they're constantly praising as the backbone of American capitalism, but I was rebuffed. They told me that specialists do not customarily grant interviews and are best kept isolated from the outside world, due to legal problems and that kind of thing.

Not giving up so easily, I redialed the PR department several times and was connected to as many different representatives, and the best response I got was: "Write us a letter." Having no patience for letters, I abandoned all hope of getting official approval. Meanwhile, I came across a *New York Times* article on Wall Street, in which an expert named William Hayes was quoted several times. Though Mr. Hayes said nothing about specialists, he sounded so astute in general that I called him up and introduced myself. In a happy coincidence, it turned out that Mr. Hayes worked for a firm of specialists himself.